

Studied Division

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Catholic Archbishop Andrus Thazhath's threat to launch a Vimochana Samaram (liberation struggle) against the LDF Government, like the one that had helped oust the first Communist government 50 years ago, seems to have fizzled out. Thazhath, who heads the Syro-Malabar diocese of Trissur, was enraged at the Government's alleged attempts to control educational institutions run by the church.

The Muslim League pledged its support to Thazhath, but some Hindu groups and even backward Christians who had supported the original Vimochana Samaram distanced themselves from the bishop and the league. "In 1959, the Centre had dismissed our



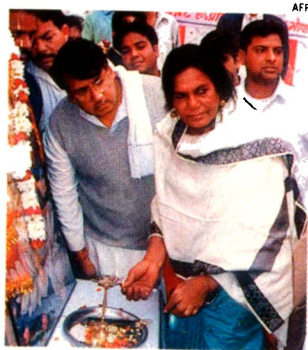
ENRAGED: Thazhath government to appease religious and casteist groups which had organised the struggle. Today we are in a position to dismiss the Central Government. How can they do anything to us?" sniped home minister, CPI(M)'s Kodieryi Bala-krishnan.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

Deadly Identity Crisis

JABALPUR After their meteoric political rise in Madhya Pradesh, the third gender is caught in a deadly battle of identity. So much so that Kamala Jaan, the first eunuch mayor of the country, has been receiving death threats and two eunuchs have been murdered in Jabalpur.

Some gangs of unemployed youths have been masquerading as eunuchs to make money through their ritualistic traditions associated with marriage and childbirth, leading to rising animosity between real and fake eunuchs.



GENDER BENDER: Jaan Now, to get to the bottom of the issue, the state Government is planning to get the eunuch populace of Jabalpur undergo a gender test to separate the genuine from the fake.

by Ambresh Mishra

SEEDHI BAAT ON AAJ TAK

"I want a new generation in politics"

BCCI PRESIDENT AND NCP CHIEF SHARAD PAWAR SPOKE to Editor PRABHU CHAWLA about the presidential polls

Q. Your party supported Pratibha Patil for President.

A. There was no consensus on any other name.

Q. Was Pranab Mukherjee's name proposed?

A. I was never asked about Pranab Mukherjee.

Q. How did you agree on Pratibha Patil?

A. The Left was in her support. I've known her for 40 years. We worked together in Vasant Rao Naik's and Shankar Rao Chauhan's governments in Maharashtra.

Q. Are you supporting a woman or a Maharashtrian?

A. First a woman, and a capable woman. Her being a Maharashtrian is a reason to rejoice.

Q. You've rejected all charges against her.

A. All these charges came up only after the announcement of her candidature; they're all false.

Q. Don't we need an inquiry against her?

A. No. There are no personal allegations against her, only those influenced by the Opposition. Why were there no charges against her while she was the governor in BJP-ruled Rajasthan?

Q. Have you been consulted on the vice-presidential candidate?

A. No. We'll shortlist the candidature for the vice-president only after the presidential polls.

Q. You seem anxious about defections in the President poll?

A. Bhairon Singh is my friend. I have no personal complaint against him. But why is he repeatedly saying that he will depend on cross-voting? It's not good for the vice-president to talk about cross-voting.

Q. Why were you miffed with President Kalam?

A. He said he'd consider a second term only if he was assured a victory. One didn't expect that from him.

Q. You have been appointed president of the ICC.

A. I'm the vice-president. I'll take over as the ICC president in 2010 for a two-year term. I don't have time for cricket. General elections are in 2009 and my party would prefer to go to Parliament through indirect election, that is, the Rajya Sabha.

Q. So you have no political ambitions after 2009?

A. My ambition is to put forward a new generation in politics. Most NCP ministers are 40 years old.

Seedhi Baat is telecast on Aaj Tak at 8.30 p.m. every Sunday and 3.30 p.m. every Monday

Full text of the interview at:

<http://www.indiatoday.com>

